

items in the launcher to re-position them. All of this is much more than what the default GNOME 3 panel or *Activities* screen does.

In the top-left corner of the screen is the icon for the Dash, a feature similar to the applications lens, which allows you to search for or browse installed applications. The short-cut key for the Dash is the OS (Windows) logo key.

As for the rest, since Unity runs atop GNOME, the basic interface is that provided by GNOME itself.

The outer reaches

We now come to the outermost aspect of our giants—the environment they provide for actually getting work (or play) done on the computer. The most famous component of this environment is probably the office suite. Both Lovelock and Natty include version 3.3.2 of LibreOffice, the new fork of the popular OpenOffice.org suite of applications. LibreOffice is owned and operated by the community, so there is no concern of it being monopolised by any single entity. Also, the new suite has the crucial support of several big companies. It will be best if OpenOffice can be merged into LibreOffice, thus liberating it from Oracle, but as of now, most major GNU/Linux distributions are switching over to LibreOffice.

Apart from this, the rest of the software is also pretty standard and up to date. What is not available in the live or installation discs can, of course, be installed from the repositories. The installers are, as usual, radically different in the two distros. The venerable Synaptic Package Manager is available in Natty, just as it should be. However, the new software manager, Ubuntu Software Centre, has seen some improvements. It now allows for purchasing software directly through its interface (although a bug prevented me from actually going through with a purchase at one go), and it also now shows libraries and other non-GUI software in search results, on demand, apart from providing some recommendations based on your searches and installations. The standard PackageKit installer in Lovelock, on the other hand, seems pretty bare-bones in comparison. It allows simple configuration of the software sources, but is nowhere near Synaptic in power. However, YUM, the installation back-end on Lovelock, scores an extremely important point over the Debian Apt in Natty—it allows delta packages to be downloaded. A delta is just the code that is different in a new version of a package that is already installed. Downloading deltas instead of entire packages saves huge amounts of time and bandwidth for data transfers during upgrades.

However, yet another factor negatively affecting Lovelock is that Fedora does not have integrated repositories for proprietary software. It depends on the external RPM Fusion and Livna repositories, and they may not always follow the latest Fedora release on time.

For example, RPM Fusion did not have the proprietary drivers for the Broadcom BCM4312 Wi-Fi chip for the current Lovelock kernel even several days after the Lovelock release (they are available now, though there is no guarantee that they will be available on time in case of a kernel upgrade). Ubuntu, on the other hand, has always had integrated proprietary software repositories. They are not supported by Canonical, of course, but they do track the latest Ubuntu release correctly and Natty is no exception.

The verdict

Instead of beating about the bush, it is better to admit that, as of now, Natty is much more usable than Lovelock. However, there are some points that must still be taken into consideration. First of all, the future of GNOME is GNOME 3. Even the next version of Ubuntu will have GNOME 3 as its base for Unity. So, whether you like it or not, if you want to stay with GNOME, you will have to consider GNOME 3 sometime or the other. Thus, you may want to delve into it right away, and report whatever bugs and missing features you encounter, so that the software matures more quickly; after all, free software is dependent not on corporations, but on users. And besides, KDE version 4.6 also has some serious bugs (such as PolicyKit randomly crashing at the end of a session), which have not yet been addressed by the developers.

Also, Fedora is known for its leadership and innovation in the GNU/Linux field. If you want to stay absolutely current on the Free Software front, Fedora is the way to go. Lovelock, for example, has a dynamically configurable firewall, which means that you do not have to stop and restart the firewall to effect some changes to its rules. You also should keep in mind that if you choose Fedora, you will not just start up to date, but you will also stay up to date. For example, a Fedora release will, as long as it is supported, keep getting the latest versions of all its software, including the kernel and desktop environment, which is not the case with Ubuntu.

The final decision is, of course, up to you. Both Lovelock and Natty are critical releases that pave the way for the future of the GNU/Linux desktop. Whether you are comfortable with handling the latest stuff, with the occasional trip-up, or want the relative safety of a traditional environment, the choice is yours. Whichever you choose, you will be a participant in one of the most important revolutions in the free software world, instead of being a mere spectator. **END.** 

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